

TRACK RECORD

▶ **More than 60 per cent (1,749 km) of work on the western and eastern corridors is completed; DFCCIL is confident of completing 99.68 per cent (2,834 km) by end-2023**

▶ **Land acquisition is all but complete except for patches on a 2-km stretch between Vaitarna and JNPA in Maharashtra on the Western DFC; an additional 375 km on the Eastern DFC is planned under the PM Gati Shakti-National Master Plan**

▶ **At full capacity, each freight train will be 1.5-km long, carry around 12,000 tonnes of cargo and run at a top speed of 100 km per hour, which is among the fastest for freight trains globally**

▶ **DFCCIL plans a new tariff framework to offer the lowest cargo carriage rates in the industry as well as look at the bulk carriage of non-conventional cargo that is currently moved using road transport**

▶ **Detailed project reports for the development of three new corridors on the East Coast, East-West and North-South routes are currently under preparation**

costs and accelerate the development of new industrial hubs,” says Rampraveen Swaminathan, MD & CEO of Mahindra Logistics.

The National Logistics Policy launched in September 2022 seeks to cut the current cost of transporting India-made goods internally and to the world by half, by 2030. Logistics costs in India are 16 per cent compared to 10 per cent in China. Besides, a rail-based solution is an environmentally friendly mass transport system.

“Railways are about 12 times more efficient in freight traffic and three times more efficient in passenger traffic compared to road transport. As the Indian economy transitions, with economic growth and sustainable development as twin goals, mobility will play a key role,” says J.B. Singh, Director of MOVIN Express, a business-to-business logistics player. Singh also has a suggestion for DFCCIL. “We recommend greater transparency in the operations of the DFCs to help build trust with logistics providers and shippers. This could include sharing data on train schedules, freight volumes and transit times.”

Per estimates, the logistics sector is required to grow by 25 per cent to meet the requirement of moving goods. Since 1951, the railway sector’s share as a transporter of freight traffic has declined from 86.2 per cent to 27 per cent today. DFCCIL proposes to reclaim the railway’s share in freight traffic by running faster, heavier, higher and longer trains on the upcoming corridors.

Meanwhile, as the Indian Railways’ special purpose vehicle, DFCCIL is working on detailed project reports to ring-fence the entire country, with railway corridors spanning the country’s eastern to western coasts, to cover a 4,300-km distance. Delivering resources to any part of the country in a jiffy could be a reality soon. **BT**

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| **FMCG** |

LET IT RAIN

Makers of consumer staples are praying for a normal monsoon and a good harvest to provide a fillip to demand and ease volume pressures

BY ARNAB DUTTA

▶ **FARMERS AREN’T THE** only ones praying for a good monsoon this year. The country’s leading FMCG firms, too, are banking on a normal monsoon for a recovery in demand and easing of margin pressures. As the makers of consumer staples—from soaps to biscuits—continue to grapple with the impact of steep commodity inflation and subdued volume offtake, a good harvest in the upcoming monsoon season

| 17

ANALYSTS ARE UNSURE ABOUT THE PROSPECTS OF A NORMAL MONSOON THIS YEAR

could help in their revival.

Take, for instance, Hindustan Unilever (HUL), which is witnessing signs of commodity prices peaking. In the December quarter, HUL and other winter personal care product makers suffered from subdued sales due to a mild winter. This, preceded by a prolonged commodity inflation, has resulted in poor volume growth at least in the past five quarters, and has kept margins under pressure. Sanjiv Mehta, CEO & MD of HUL, says the FMCG industry has witnessed unprecedented inflation across a